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Level 200 • First Semester • Handout

FEDERAL UNIVERSITY OF PETROLEUM RESOURCES

COLLEGE OF SCIENCE

DEPARTMENT OF COMPUTER SCIENCE

GSE PRESENTATION

ON

‘THE DOUBTING OF THE SOPHIST GAVE BIRTH TO THE ENTERPRISE CALLED
EPISTEMOLOGY’ DISCUSS

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OVERVIEW

The debates between the sophists and their critics laid the groundwork for the development of epistemology as a distinct philosophical discipline. Epistemologists sought to address questions raised by sophism, such as: How can we distinguish between true and false beliefs? What are the sources of knowledge? Can knowledge be certain?

In summary, the doubting attitude of the sophists played a crucial role in stimulating philosophical inquiry and ultimately gave rise to epistemology as philosophers sought to provide systematic answers to questions about the nature and limits of human knowledge.

1. THE ORIGIN OF EPISTEMOLOGY

The origin of epistemology as a formal discipline can be traced back to ancient Greek philosophy.

The term "epistemology" itself originates from the Greek words "episteme," meaning knowledge, and

"logos," meaning study or discourse. While ancient Greek philosophers addressed questions related to knowledge and truth, it was during the period of intense philosophical inquiry in the 5th and 4th centuries BCE that the groundwork for epistemology as a distinct field was laid.

While the specific "birth" of epistemology is complex and open to debate, the seeds were undeniably

sown by the Sophists in ancient Greece (5th century BC). Their skepticism and questioning of established knowledge challenged pre-existing assumptions and sparked a need for deeper inquiry into the nature of knowledge itself. Here's a breakdown of the key players and contributing factors:

THE SOPHISTS:

- A group of skilled teachers and intellectuals known for their rhetorical and critical thinking skills.
- Introduced relativism, questioning the existence of absolute truths and highlighting the subjectivity of perception.

- Used skepticism and critical interrogation to expose inconsistencies and contradictions in arguments, shaking the foundations of traditional beliefs and values.

THE PHILOSOPHERS' RESPONSE:

- SOCRATES: Developed the "elenchus," a method of critical questioning to expose contradictions and inconsistencies in arguments.
- PLATO: Sought to identify ultimate and unchanging truths beyond the realm of sense perception, proposing his theory of Forms as a source of true knowledge.
- ARISTOTLE: Investigated the different ways we acquire knowledge through experience, reason, and intuition, laying the groundwork for later empiricist and rationalist thought.

OTHER CONTRIBUTORS:

- THE DEVELOPMENT OF SCIENCE: Growing emphasis on critical thinking and the expansion

of scientific knowledge fueled the need for robust methods of evaluating evidence and claims.

□ CULTURAL AND INTELLECTUAL FACTORS: The flourishing of philosophy and debate in ancient Greece fostered an environment conducive to questioning and exploring fundamental concepts.

While the seeds were sown by the Sophists, it's important to remember that:

□ Epistemology's development is complex and ongoing, with contributions from diverse thinkers across different eras.

□ The Sophists' influence wasn't uniform; some embraced relativism, while others focused on manipulating beliefs.

□ Skepticism and the search for certainty have remained driving forces in epistemological debates throughout history

2. SOPHISTRY AND SKEPTICISM: EXAMINING DOUBT AS A CATALYST FOR EPISTEMOLOGICAL INQUIRY

The statement that "the doubting of the Sophists gave birth to the enterprise called Epistemology" contains a significant element of truth, but it requires some nuance and additional context. Here's a breakdown:

SOPHISTS AND THEIR "DOUBT":

Sophists were influential educators and thinkers in ancient Greece (5th-4th century BC).

Their emphasis was on rhetoric, argumentation, and the power of persuasion, often playing with relativism and subjectivity.

While the term "doubt" might not fully capture their approach, Sophists certainly challenged traditional views on knowledge and truth. They questioned the basis of authority, argued for the multiplicity of perspectives, and highlighted the role of language and context in shaping knowledge.

BIRTH OF EPISTEMOLOGY:

Epistemology, the branch of philosophy concerned with the nature, sources, and limits of knowledge, did indeed gain momentum around the same time as the Sophists' influence.

However, it's not accurate to say that the Sophists solely birthed this enterprise. Philosophers like Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle were also instrumental in its development. They responded to the Sophists' challenges by engaging in deeper inquiries about the possibility of objective knowledge, the role of reason and perception, and the justification of beliefs.

Therefore, a more accurate picture would be:

The Sophists' skeptical and relativistic approach served as a catalyst for the systematic exploration of knowledge, pushing philosophers to articulate and defend their positions.

The birth of Epistemology was fueled by various factors, including the Sophists' challenges,

but also the intellectual curiosity and philosophical inquiries of other thinkers.

Points to consider further:

Not all Sophists embraced complete relativism. Some, like Protagoras, explored the idea of "human measures" as a basis for knowledge, acknowledging a degree of shared experience. While the Sophists often challenged traditional views, they weren't necessarily pure skeptics. Their aim was more about demonstrating the power of persuasion and the malleability of knowledge, not necessarily denying its existence altogether.

The development of Epistemology continues well beyond the ancient Greek era, with contributions from various philosophical schools and historical periods.

The Sophists' intellectual contributions did play a significant role in the development of Epistemology, but it's important to acknowledge the broader context and the involvement of other thinkers in this crucial philosophical endeavor.

Skepticism, in its essence, is an attitude of doubt or disbelief towards claims or principles that are widely accepted.

It's not about being a pessimist or a naysayer, but rather about being open to questioning and exploring different possibilities.

THE IMPORTANCE OF DOUBT IN PHILOSOPHICAL INQUIRY

Doubt plays a crucial role in philosophical inquiry. It acts as a catalyst for critical thinking and intellectual exploration.

Without doubt, we might be content with superficial explanations and unquestioned assumptions.

It's doubt that pushes us to dig deeper, to examine the foundations of our beliefs, and to challenge the status quo.

In philosophy, doubt serves as a means to seek truth and knowledge. By questioning what we think we know, we open ourselves to new perspectives and insights.

Doubt keeps us on our toes, reminding us that knowledge is an ongoing journey, not a fixed destination.

THE HISTORICAL DEVELOPMENT OF SKEPTICISM IN PHILOSOPHY

ANCIENT GREEK SKEPTICISM: PYRRHONISM AND ACADEMIC SKEPTICISM

Skepticism has a rich history, dating back to ancient Greece. The Pyrrhonists, led by Pyrrho of Elis, believed that absolute certainty was unattainable and that suspension of judgment was the wisest approach. They challenged dogmas and argued that one should remain in a state of doubt.

Academic skepticism, on the other hand, emerged from Plato's Academy. Carneades, a prominent figure in this school, advocated for suspending judgment and considering multiple

perspectives.

Academic skeptics highlighted the limitations of human knowledge and emphasized the importance of intellectual humility.

RENAISSANCE AND ENLIGHTENMENT SKEPTICISM

During the Renaissance and Enlightenment periods, skepticism regained popularity.

Philosophers like Michel de Montaigne and David Hume questioned traditional beliefs and examined the limits of human understanding. They challenged authority and encouraged independent thinking.

Skepticism became a tool for intellectual liberation, promoting individual autonomy and critical inquiry.

It laid the groundwork for scientific reasoning and the development of empirical methods.

MODERN AND CONTEMPORARY SKEPTICISM

In modern and contemporary philosophy, skepticism continues to thrive. Philosophers like Ludwig Wittgenstein and Willard Van Orman Quine have explored the nature of doubt and language, challenging our assumptions about knowledge and reality. They highlight the complexities of language and its role in shaping our understanding of the world.

Moreover, advancements in fields such as cognitive science have led to new forms of skepticism, questioning our cognitive biases and the reliability of our perceptions.

THE EPISTEMOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE OF DOUBT

DOUBT AS A CATALYST FOR KNOWLEDGE AND TRUTH

Doubt is not an enemy of knowledge; it is its ally. By embracing doubt, we open ourselves to the possibility of discovering new truths and expanding our understanding.

Doubt challenges us to critically examine the evidence and reasoning behind our beliefs, ensuring that our knowledge is well-founded and reliable.

In this sense, doubt serves as a driving force behind the advancement of knowledge. It encourages us to question authority, to challenge conventional wisdom, and to engage in rigorous intellectual inquiry.

DESCARTES AND THE METHOD OF DOUBT

René Descartes, the famous philosopher and mathematician, elevated doubt to a methodological tool in his philosophical investigations.

In his pursuit of certainty, he employed the method of doubt — systematically doubting all his beliefs until he reached indubitable truths.

Descartes' method of doubt aimed to establish a foundation of knowledge by ridding it of any doubts or uncertainties.

Though his approach had its limitations, it highlighted the importance of skepticism and

doubt in philosophical discourse.

SKEPTICISM AS A METHODOLOGICAL TOOL IN PHILOSOPHICAL INQUIRY

THE ROLE OF SKEPTICISM IN FOUNDATIONALISM AND COHERENTISM

Skepticism plays a vital role in two major theories of epistemology: foundationalism and coherentism.

Foundationalism posits that knowledge is built upon basic, self-evident beliefs. Skepticism acts as a tool for scrutinizing these foundational beliefs and ensuring their legitimacy.

Coherentism, on the other hand, emphasizes the coherence and interconnection of beliefs.

Skepticism serves as a means to critically evaluate the consistency and logical coherence of our beliefs, ensuring that they form a reliable web of knowledge.

SKEPTICISM AND THE PROBLEM OF INDUCTION

Skepticism also enters the stage when we encounter the problem of induction. The problem of induction refers to the challenge of justifying general conclusions based on limited observations.

Skepticism reminds us that our observations, no matter how many, do not necessarily guarantee the truth of our generalizations.

By acknowledging this problem, skepticism urges us to be cautious in our claims and to be aware of the limitations of our inductive reasoning.

In conclusion, doubt and skepticism are indispensable elements in philosophy. They drive intellectual exploration, challenge established beliefs, and push us to continually seek knowledge and truth.

3. EPISTEMOLOGY AS AN INTELLECTUAL ENTERPRISE EVOLUTION AND DEVELOPMENT

Epistemology, the study of knowledge and its acquisition, has evolved significantly throughout history, shaped by various intellectual movements, philosophical debates, and scientific advancements. Understanding its evolution and development provides insights into how humans have grappled with fundamental questions about what we can know and how we can know it.

1. ANCIENT ROOTS: Epistemological inquiries can be traced back to ancient civilizations such as Mesopotamia, Egypt, and Greece. In these early periods, thinkers like Plato and Aristotle pondered questions about the nature of knowledge, truth, and justification. Plato's theory of Forms and Aristotle's emphasis on empirical observation laid foundational ideas for later developments.

2. MEDIEVAL PERIOD: During the Middle Ages, epistemology was heavily influenced by theological concerns. Figures like Augustine and Aquinas sought to reconcile faith with

reason, exploring the relationship between divine revelation and human understanding. This era saw the integration of religious doctrines with philosophical inquiry, shaping the trajectory of epistemology for centuries to come.

3. RENAISSANCE AND ENLIGHTENMENT: The Renaissance ushered in a renewed interest in humanism and empirical observation, paving the way for the scientific revolution. Thinkers like Descartes, Bacon, and Locke challenged traditional authorities and emphasized the role of reason and experience in acquiring knowledge. Descartes' methodological doubt and Locke's empiricism laid the groundwork for modern epistemology, emphasizing skepticism and empiricism respectively.

4. MODERN AND CONTEMPORARY ERA: The development of modern science further transformed epistemology. Figures like Kant revolutionized the field by exploring the limitations of human knowledge and the role of perception and cognition in shaping our understanding of reality. The rise of analytic philosophy in the 20th century, led by thinkers like Russell and Wittgenstein, introduced new methodologies and conceptual frameworks for studying knowledge and language.

5. POSTMODERN CRITIQUES: In more recent decades, postmodernist thinkers have critiqued traditional epistemological frameworks, challenging notions of objective truth and universal knowledge. Figures like Foucault and Derrida highlighted the role of power, language, and social constructs in shaping knowledge, sparking debates about relativism and the nature of reality.

6. INTERDISCIPLINARY INFLUENCES: Epistemology has also been enriched by interdisciplinary influences, drawing insights from fields such as cognitive science, psychology, and sociology. Advances in these disciplines have provided new perspectives on how knowledge is acquired, processed, and communicated, prompting reevaluations of traditional epistemological theories.

7. CONTEMPORARY DEBATES: Contemporary epistemology continues to grapple with pressing questions about the nature of knowledge, including issues such as the reliability of scientific methods, the impact of technology on cognition, and the role of social and cultural factors in shaping beliefs. Debates between foundationalists, coherentists, and reliabilists persist, reflecting ongoing attempts to reconcile competing epistemological frameworks. In summary, epistemology as an intellectual enterprise has undergone a complex and multifaceted evolution, shaped by historical, philosophical, and scientific developments. Its journey reflects humanity's enduring quest to understand the nature, limits, and sources of knowledge, navigating through diverse perspectives, challenges, and insights along the way.

4. THE QUEST FOR KNOWLEDGE: EPISTEMOLOGICAL METHODS AND

APPROACHES

METHODS/APPROACHES IN EPISTEMOLOGY

Epistemology, the branch of philosophy concerned with the nature, scope, and limitations of knowledge, employs various methods and approaches to explore fundamental questions about what we can know, how we can know it, and what constitutes valid knowledge. From ancient philosophical dialogues to modern scientific investigations, epistemologists have employed diverse methods and approaches to understand the nature of knowledge which include;

1. **RATIONALISM:** Rationalism emphasizes the role of reason and intellectual intuition in acquiring knowledge. Rationalists argue that certain truths can be known independently of sensory experience through the use of pure reason. Philosophers like René Descartes, Baruch Spinoza, and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz are notable philosophers of rationalism. Descartes, for instance, famously used methodological skepticism in his *Meditations* to establish a foundation of indubitable knowledge through the cogito argument ("I think, therefore I am").
2. **SKEPTICISM:** Skepticism is a position that questions the possibility of human knowledge, either in particular domains or on a general level. Skepticism does not refer to any one specific school of philosophy, but is rather a thread that runs through many epistemological debates. Ancient Greek skepticism began during the Hellenistic period in philosophy, Epistemic skepticism questions whether knowledge is possible at all. Generally speaking, skeptics argue that knowledge requires certainty, and that most or all of our beliefs are fallible (meaning that our grounds for holding them always, or almost always, fall short of certainty), which would together entail that knowledge is always or almost always impossible for us. Characterizing knowledge as strong or weak is dependent on a person's viewpoint and their characterization of knowledge. Much of modern epistemology is derived from attempts to better understand and address philosophical skepticism. Modern skeptics like David Hume raised questions about causality and induction, highlighting the limitations of human understanding.
3. **PRAGMATISM:** Pragmatism is a fallible method of epistemology that emphasizes the role of action in knowing. Pragmatists argue that the meaning and truth of beliefs are determined by their practical effects on human behavior and experience. Figures such as Charles Sanders Peirce, William James, and John Dewey are key proponents of pragmatism. William James, in his essay "The Will to Believe," defends the rationality of adopting beliefs based on their practical value. In James's pragmatic method, which he adapted from Peirce, metaphysical disputes can be settled by tracing the practical consequences of the different sides of the argument. If this process does not resolve the dispute, then "the dispute is idle". Different interpretations of pragmatism variously emphasize truth as the final outcome of ideal

scientific inquiry and experimentation, truth as closely related to usefulness, experience as transacting with (instead of representing) nature, and human practices as the foundation of language. Pragmatism's origins are often attributed to Charles Sanders Peirce, William James, and John Dewey. In 1878, Peirce formulated the maxim: "Consider what effects, that might conceivably have practical bearings, we conceive the object of our conception to have. Then, our conception of these effects is the whole of our conception of the object."

4. FEMINIST EPISTEMOLOGY: Feminist epistemology is a subfield of epistemology which applies feminist theory to epistemological questions. It examines how gender biases and power dynamics influence epistemic practices and structures.

The feminist epistemology began to emerge as a distinct subfield in the 20th century. Prominent feminist epistemologists include Miranda Fricker (who developed the concept of epistemic injustice), Donna Haraway (who first proposed the concept of situated knowledge) and Sandra Harding, Harding proposes that feminist epistemology can be broken into three distinct categories: feminist empiricism, standpoint epistemology, and postmodern epistemology.

5. PYRRHONISM: One of the oldest forms of epistemic skepticism can be found in Agrippa's trilemma (named after the Pyrrhonist philosopher Agrippa the Skeptic) which demonstrates that certainty cannot be achieved with regard to beliefs. Pyrrhonism dates back to Pyrrho of Elis from the 4th century BCE, although most of what we know about Pyrrhonism today is from the surviving works of Sextus Empiricus. Pyrrhonists claim that for any argument for a non-evident proposition, an equally convincing argument for a contradictory proposition can be produced. Pyrrhonists do not dogmatically deny the possibility of knowledge, but instead point out that beliefs about non-evident matters cannot be substantiated.

6. EMPIRICISM: Empiricism is a view in the theory of knowledge which focuses on the role of experience, especially experience based on perceptual observations by the senses, in the generation of knowledge. Empiricists argue that all ideas originate from sensory impressions and that the mind is a blank slate (tabula rasa) at birth. Figures such as John Locke, George Berkeley, and David Hume are prominent empiricists who have shaped this tradition. Locke's Essay Concerning Human Understanding, for example, states that the mind acquires knowledge through sensation and reflection, rejecting the notion of innate ideas.

Other methods of Epistemology include;

- a) Naturalism, d) Critical Realism,
- b) Epistemic constructivism, e) Subjectivism,
- c) Epistemic relativism, f) Objectivisme.t.c.

5. RATIONALISM VS. EMPIRICISM: MAJOR SCHOOLS OF THOUGHT IN

EPISTEMOLOGY

Rationalism is a theory of philosophy in which it is believed that reason and logic are the main sources of knowledge. It is a methodology that says that justification or reason is the view that shows the basis of knowledge. Any justification which is given with a reason or a logic, that is intellectual is rationalism. Rationalists believe that everything has a logic behind it, reality has logic and logical knowledge is correct.

Rationalists believe that logic and reasons can reveal the reality of the world, that some truths exist which can be grasped directly through the intellect. Rationalism can be seen in logical reasoning, mathematics, morals and ethics, and metaphysics. Rationalists highly believe that the reason is fundamentally true and they cannot be denied. They believe that knowledge is independent of sensory experience.

There are three basic claims in rationalism. Out of these three claims, rationalists have to adopt at least one. These three thesis are the intuition or deduction thesis, the innate knowledge thesis, and the innate concept thesis. In addition to these, there are two more theories, although a person can be a rationalist without adopting either of them. One is the claim of Indispensability of Reason and the second one is the Superiority of Reason claim. The philosopher and historian William James criticizes the theory of rationalism because it is outdated and does not touch reality. He opposed that the rationalist represents the world as a closed system.

EMPIRICISM

Empiricism is the term used in philosophy, which states that experimentation and sensory experience is the major source of knowledge. Rather than ideas empiricism emphasized the pieces of evidence. Experiments and evidence show the reality of the world, according to empiricists.

Throughout history, the theory of empiricism is described as a blank slate that is filled with experience over time. The human mind is like the blank slate which is empty by birth and is filled in by experience, learning, and experiments. Knowledge is based on the experience we gain, the possibilities and probabilities of our actions, the falsification, the experimental procedure.

The word Empirical is derived from an ancient Greek word “empeiria”, which means experience. The history of the belief in empiricism goes far back to 600 to 200 BCE. An ancient Indian philosopher named Kanada had accepted that the two sources of knowledge are perception and inference. This is mentioned in his work called Vaisesika Sutra, which is an ancient Sanskrit text.

Empiricists believe that experience, and memory develops the person and his morals. They

also believe that evidence, any kind of proof which is found by experiment, can reveal the world's reality, rather than reason and logic.

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN RATIONALISM AND EMPIRICISM

Basis of Comparison: Rationalism, Empiricism

DEFINITION

Rationalism is the term used in philosophy to refer to the knowledge that is derived from reason and logic.

Empiricism is the term used in philosophy in which the main source of knowledge is experience and experiments.

BELIEF

Rationalists believe that reason can explain the working of the world.

The empiricists believe that evidence through experimentation can explain reality.

PRINCIPLES

Rationalism is related to mental processes and organizing principles.

Empiricism is related to sensory experience and association principles.

HISTORY

The history of rationalism goes far beyond the Pythagoras' time that is 570–495 BCE.

The history of empiricism goes to the era between 600 to 200 BCE.

EXAMPLES

Mathematics is an example of rationalism.

Experimental Science is an example of empiricism.

In conclusion, Rationalism and Empiricism are both terms used in philosophy. Both the terms are used under the term epistemology, which is a branch of philosophy concerned with knowledge. Although the terms sound the same, they are too different from each other.

Actually, the terms have always been used as opposed to each other. Rationalism regards reasons and logic as the main source of knowledge. They believe in the reasoning behind things and reality. Rationalists believe logic and reason will explain the world's reality and they also believe that they are independent of sensory experience. While Rationalism is about intuition, empiricism is about visual concepts.

6. CONTEMPORARY ISSUES IN EPISTEMOLOGY: TECHNOLOGY, ETHICS AND COGNITIVE SCIENCE

They help to shape the way we understand, acquire, share and evaluate knowledge. Some of these issues include.

1. **ADVANCEMENT IN TECHNOLOGY:** Due to the advancement of digital technology, creation of social media platforms and the advancement of the internet at large, production,

Dissemination and Consumption of knowledge have greatly change over time posing its own challenge on the system. And one of the major issue caused by the advancement of technology is the sharing of fake news or fake knowledge.

2. COGNITIVE SCIENCE OR MIND SCIENCE: It explains how our mind can acquire and shapen knowledge. It also explains the relationship between the mental processes and our ability as humans to understand, acquire, disseminate and evaluate knowledge in order to prevent misinformation or errors in judgment and belief system.

3. THE ROLE OF ETHICS IN EPISTEMOLOGY: Ethics explains the moral principles and responsibilities of how we acquire, share and apply knowledge. It helps to resolve issues like bias, diversity, misinformation and technology and helps to foster truth, trust and accountability in knowledge practices.

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FEDERAL UNIVERSITY OF PETROLEUM

RESOURCES, EFFURUN, DELTA STATE.

DEPARTMENT OF CHEMISTRY (INDUSTRIAL

CHEMISTRY)

GSE 211 PRESENTATION

TOPIC:

ETHICS AS A MAJOR BRANCH OF PHILOSOPHY

LECTURER:

MISS JOACHIM IRERUKE UKUTSEMUYA

20TH FEBRUARY, 2024.

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INTRODUCTION TO ETHICS

Ethics is a branch of philosophy that looks into the rightness and wrongness of an action. It is also a branch of philosophy that concern itself with good and evil nature of actions, and seeks to guide behaviors in a way that increases good actions in the society.

The word Ethics is derived from a Greek word 'Ethos' which means 'way of living'. Ethical philosophy began in the fifth century BCE with the appearance of Socrates a secular prophet whose self appointed mission was to awaken his fellow men to the need for rational criticism of their belief and practice.

DEFINITIONS

- According to Richard Williams Paul and Linda Elder, ethics is a set of concepts and principle that guides us in determining what behavior helps or harms sentient creatures.
- The Cambridge Dictionary of Philosophy states that the word Ethics is commonly used interchangeably with morality, and sometimes it is used more narrowly to mean the moral principles of a particular tradition, or group of individuals.
- According to Laura Annabelle, Ethics can also be seen as moral philosophy. It is a branch of philosophy that involves systemizing, defending, and recommending concepts of right and wrong conducts.
- William Lillie in his book 'An Introduction to Ethics' defines it as the systematic study of the fundamental principle of the moral law, the normative science of human conducts.
- Joseph Omoregbe sees ethics as the branch of philosophy which deals with the morality of human actions. For him, it is a branch of philosophy which deals with the study of the human behavior.

Ethical philosophy or moral philosophy is concerned with the issues of duty.

CATEGORIES OF ETHICS

There are three (3) categories of ethical theories which includes;

1. Normative Ethics: This is a branch of moral philosophy, or ethics concerned with criterias of what is morally right or wrong. It includes the formulation of moral rules that have direct implications for what human action, institutios, and way of life should be like. Normative Ethics is basically the guidelines we use to live our lives, it shapes our decision making. Some common examples of Normative Ethics include things like honesty, respect, and fairness. Normative questions are much broader, and entail our value. For example;

Do not kill an innocent person.

The normative here is the respect for human dignity for all person.

2. Applied Ethics: This is a branch of ethics devoted to the treatment of moral problem, practices, and policies in personal life, professions, technology and government.

Applied Ethics refers to any use of philosophical methods to treat moral problems. It dwells on general moral issues which includes;

- Abortion
- Euthanasia giving to the poor
- Sex before marriage
- The death penalty
- Gay/lesbian marriage
- War tactics
- Censorship
- So called 'white lies' etc

Applied Ethics has four main ethical principle and they are; Beneficence, non maleficence, autonomy, and justice.

3. Meta-ethics: Meta ethics is the study of nature, scope, and meaning of moral judgement. It is one of the three branches of ethics generally studied by philosophers. It explores the status, foundations and scope of moral values, properties and words. Major meta ethical theories includes naturalism, non-naturalism (or intuitionism), emotivism, and prescriptivism. Meta ethical question includes;

- What does it means to say something is good?
- How do we know what is right and wrong?
- How do moral attitudes motivate action?
- What is goodness?
- What should I do?

ERAS OF ETHICS

Ethics is classified into three (3) eras namely;

1. Classical era
2. Modern era
3. Applied Ethic era

THE CLASSICAL ERA (429-347BC)

The Classical Era was a time in ancient Greek history where groundbreaking ideas took center stage. Think of it as a golden age of philosophy, art, and innovation, with great thinkers like Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle shaping the intellectual landscape.

The Ethical philosophies in the classical era responded to two basic questions: What is the good Life for people? How should people behave? The ethical philosophies of such people as Plato, Aristotle, Epicurus, Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill, Emmanuel Kant fall within the classical era.

PLATO:

Plato, for instance, in response to the above two questions: What is the good life? How ought people to behave? opines that the good life is premised an intellectual life. He holds that when one knows the good life, he will not be immoral. There is thus emphasis on knowing that is, people do the wrong because they do not know the right or the good. Education becomes a means of eradicating immoral behaviour as it helps to know the right and wrong. Popkin and Stroll, referring to the ethical philosophy of Plato, hold that Plato so long envisaged ruling class of both men and women. In such a society, the rulers have developed their intellectual capacities, and would also have acquired knowledge: and having acquired knowledge, they would understand the nature of the good life. This in turn helps them act rightly, or morally, and hence would ensure their being good rulers. Thus Plato believes that if a person could acquire knowledge, in particular knowledge of what was good, then such a person would never act evil.

ARISTOTLE:

Aristotle believes that the ultimate aim of human existence is happiness. Human life in essence achieves his purpose when he is happy. He however holds that in order for man to get to this end, his action must always be based on middle of two extremes. This is why it is called the theory of the mean: for instance, in eating, between eating too much and too little.

It is expressed that courage is the mean between cowardice and rashness; liberality, between prodigality and frugality; pride between vanity and humility and so forth.

Aristotle emphasized the practical importance of developing excellence (virtue) of character as the way to achieve what is finally more important, excellent conduct. Aristotle argues that the man who possesses character, excellence will tend to do the right thing, at the right time, and in the right way. Bravery, and the correct regulation of one's bodily appetites, are examples of character excellence or virtue. So acting bravely and acting temperately are examples of excellent activities. The highest aims are living well, and eudaimonia – a Greek word often translated as well-being, happiness or "human flourishing".

Like many ethicists, Aristotle regards excellent activity as pleasurable for the man of virtue. For example, Aristotle thinks that the man whose appetites are in the correct order actually takes pleasure in acting moderately.

Aristotle emphasized that virtue is practical, and that the purpose of ethics is to become good, not merely to know.

EPICURUS:

Epicurus' ethics is based on hedonism; i.e., he says that the only thing that is valuable is one's own pleasure; anything else that has value is valuable merely as a means to securing pleasure for oneself. However, Epicurus has a sophisticated and idiosyncratic view of the nature of pleasure, which leads him to recommend a virtuous, moderately ascetic life as the best means to securing pleasure.

Epicurus agrees with Aristotle that happiness is the highest good. However, he disagrees with Aristotle by identifying happiness with pleasure. Epicurus gives two reasons for this. The main reason is that pleasure is the only thing that people do, as a matter of fact, value for its own sake; that is, Epicurus' ethical hedonism is based upon his psychological hedonism. Everything we do, claims Epicurus, we do for the sake ultimately of gaining pleasure for ourselves. This is supposedly confirmed by observing the behavior of infants, who, it is claimed, instinctively pursue pleasure and shun pain. This is also true of adults, thinks Epicurus, but in adults it is more difficult to see that this is true, since adults have much more complicated beliefs about what will bring them pleasure. But the Epicureans did spend a great deal of energy trying to make plausible the contention that all activity, even apparently self-sacrificing activity or activity done solely for the sake of virtue or what is noble, is in fact directed toward obtaining pleasure for oneself.

The second proof, which fits in well with Epicurus lies in one's introspective experience. One immediately perceives that pleasure is good and that pain is bad, in the same way that one immediately perceives that fire is hot; no further argument is needed to show the goodness of pleasure or the badness of pain. (Of course, this does not establish Epicurus' further contention that only pleasure is intrinsically valuable and only pain is intrinsically bad.)

Although all pleasures are good and all pains evil, Epicurus says that not all pleasures are choiceworthy or all pains to be avoided. Instead, one should calculate what is in one's long-term self-interest, and forgo what will bring pleasure in the short-term if doing so will ultimately lead to greater pleasure in the long-term.

JEREMY BENTHAM AND JOHN STUART MILL:

Jeremy Bentham was the father of utilitarianism, a moral theory that argues that actions should be judged right or wrong to the extent they increase or decrease human well-being, it emphasises utility and it holds that the action that brings the greatest happiness to the greatest number of people is the good act. He advocated that if the consequences of an action are good, then the act is moral and if the consequences are bad, the act is immoral.

In assessing utilitarianism, it would be found out that it makes a distinction between a motive for acting and the consequences of an action. Utilitarianism under this division, emphasises consequences; hence it talks about the satisfaction of the greatest number, it is democratic as democracy pitches with majority.

This is where ethicists start to ask tricky questions like, 'would you kill Hitler?'. And if you answer 'um, sure, because that will prevent a LOT of deaths', then they will ask, 'would you kill baby Hitler?'. You can see how it starts to get complicated.

Bentham's theory relies on accurately predicting outcomes, and as such holds the moral agent accountable for moral luck. One might intend to do a good deed, but if an unpredictable result occurs, leading to a negative outcome, then they are still to be held morally responsible.

EMMANUEL KANT:

Emmanuel Kant, a German Philosopher, goes straight to the intention or motive for an action.

He opines that only acts that come from feeling of obligation and duty qualify to be good acts. Thus if you act out of fear or inclination, your act is not qualified to be a good act. Thus in this way it emphasises the intention behind an act. A person is acting morally only when he suppresses his hind feelings and inclinations and does that which he/she is obliged to do.

Besides, to complete his system of morality, Kant introduces the term 'Categorical Imperative'. By this he means that in a given circumstance, the action that must be carried out should be one that you can wish to be a universal law, that is, a law that is applied by everybody in the world. In this way, it is not a law that is fanciful to you alone but could be universally acceptable. An application of this categorical imperative given a sense of duty in application makes one to have rightly and not wrongly acted.

THE MODERN ERA

- Subjectivistic and objectivistic: Subjectivistic is a personal view, points, experiences, or perspective. It relates with psychology of one who utters it. Objectivistic is the awarenesses or expressing awarenesses of things as they really are.

If the truth of the judgement is not in the person, but is about a certain feature of the world called 'goodness and is outside of the person who utters it, then it is also said to be objectivistic. An example of objectivistic is utilitarianism because, it depends on more than one person for it's truthfulness.

- Naturalistic, Non-naturalistic or Emotivism: Naturalistic means resembling something that exists or occurs in nature. This hold that moral judgement are true or false, but the truthfulness or falsity could be confirmed in accordance with the scientific standard. This is the reason it is said to be naturalistic. An example is utilitarianism. Non-naturalistic is the opposite of naturalistic. This holds that moral

judgement is either true or false, but the falsity or truthfulness is not open to scientific confirmation. An example is the Christian theory of morality that hinges on God's will, and Plato's concept of goodness. Emotivism is said to be the view that moral judgements do not function as statement of the facts but rather as expressions of the speaker's or writer's feelings. They are neither true nor false as they are the expression of the individual's feelings.

- Motivist, Consequences, and Deontological Theories: Motivist is defined as the doctrine that the morality of an actions is to be judged solely by it's consequences the rightness or wrongness of an action depends on the motive from which the act was done. An example of motivist is the Kant's theory. The theory of consequences (consequential) was a field of logic investigating how something follows (sequor) from something. Consequence was a wide notion that could be applied even to mean just term inclusion, but in logical theory it usually denoted the relation of following between propositions. A theory is called consequence theory if it holds that the rightness and wrongness of an action depends on the effects that the action has. An example is utilitarianism. The deontological ethics holds that at least some acts are morally obligatory regardless of their consequences for human welfare. This theory holds that the rightness or wrongness of an act depends on neither the motive or consequence, but solely on what kind of act it is. An example is when someone makes a promise, the person performs an act it's very nature obliges you to carry it out irrespective of your inclinations or effects of carrying it out.

THE CONTEMPORARY/APPLIED ERA

This era if ethics is about the application of ethics in day to day running of the society. There are so many issues in the society that requires the treatment of ethical/moral philosophy. For instance, the issue of freedom and censorship, what is the amount of freedom that should be allowed to members of a community? At what point should you begin to cause activities in the society into autocratic and democratic societies to allow members enough freedom in activities and choices.

In addition, we have the issue of Euthanasia; that is mercy killing. Should one be allowed to take the lives of other people out of pity for them? Perhaps, they are going through agony. There is the issue of Abortions. Regular one and abortions as a result of rape. In essence, should abortion be permitted under my circumstances at all? Issues like this and others are areas where we have applied ethics, that is theory in ethical philosophy treats issues to point to the most national direction to take. Here then, we have practical issues in the society asking for attention of moral philosophy.

The contemporary and applied era of ethics and philosophy is a vibrant and diverse landscape marked by a focus on real world problems, and willingness to engage with new technologies and social issues. Here are some key features of this era;

- Applied Ethics: There has been a significant shift towards applied ethics which focuses on applying ethical theories to practical problems in areas such as;
 - a. Bioethics: These are issues surrounding genetic engineering, assisted reproduction,

and end of life care.

b. Business Ethics: This cooperates social responsibilities, environment ethics, and the ethics of artificial intelligence.

c. Environmental Ethics: Includes issues of poverty, human rights and resources, informal consent, and the ethics of clinical trials.

d. Science and Technology Ethics: The development and use of new technologies such as artificial intelligence and gene editing.

● Interdisciplinarity: Ethics is no longer isolutical from other disciplines, instead it is increasingly engaging with fields such as science, law, public policy, social science, e.t.c.

The contemporary and applied era of ethics and philosophy is a dynamic and exciting time, it is a time when we are grappling with new challenges and opportunities, and when we are striving to create a more just and equitable world.

ETHICAL PRINCIPLES

Ethical principles serve as guiding values that help us determine what is morally right or wrong in different situations. They provide a framework for making ethical decisions and acting in a way that promotes fairness, integrity, and the well being of others. By considering principles such as respect for autonomy. We can navigate complex ethical dilemma, and make choices that align our values and the greater good.

These principles are like a moral compass that help us navigate the complexities of life and make ethical choices. Here are some key principles;

1. Respect for Autonomy: This principle emphasizes on the importance of respecting individual's freedom to make their own choices and decisions.
2. Beneficence: It means promoting the well being of others, and taking actions that benefits them. It is about doing good and helping others.
3. Non-maleficence: This principle focuses on avoiding harm and preventing or minimizing any potential negative consequences.
4. Justice: This is about fairness and equal treatment, it involves ensuring that everyone is treated fairly and that resources and opportunities are distributed equitably.
5. Integrity: Integrity means being honest, trustworthy, and having strong moral principles. It involves acting consistently with one's values and being accountable for one's actions.

Again, these principles serve a a moral compass, and can guide ethical decision making in various contexts, including politics. They help ensure that actions are aligned with ethical standards and promote the wellbeing of individuals and the society as a whole.

THE RELATIONSHIP OF ETHICS TO METAPHYSICS

Ethics and metaphysics are two branches of philosophy that explore different aspects of human existence, and the nature of reality. While they are distinct fields of study, there can be some connections and intersections between them.

Ethics is concerned questions of morality, values, and how we ought to behave. It examines

concepts like right and wrong, good and bad, and the principles that guide human conduct. Ethics is primarily concerned with practical matters and how we should live our lives in a morally responsible way. Metaphysics on the other hand deals with the fundamental nature of reality, existence, and the nature of being. It explores questions about existence, the existence of God, the nature of consciousness, and the relationship between mind and body amongst other topics.

So while ethics is focused on moral principles, and how we should act, metaphysics provides a broader philosophical framework within ethical questions which can be explored. For example, metaphysics beliefs about the nature of reality and human existence can influence ethical perspectives and shape our understanding of moral obligations. Metaphysics beliefs about the existence of free will that can have implications for ethical theories. If one believes in a deterministic world view, it may impact concepts of moral responsibility and accountability. Alternatively, a belief in the existence of a higher power or divine order may shape the ethical principle bases on religion or spiritual teachings.

while ethics and metaphysics are distinct branches of philosophy, they can intersect when exploring questions about nature of reality, human existence, and how these concepts inform ethical principles and decision making.

CONCLUSION

In summary, Ethics is indeed a major branch of philosophy because, it entails of all morals of life which leads to the growth of every individual, and the society at large.

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Being As A

Metaphysical

Problem

200 Level, Department of Chemistry, Federal

University of Petroleum Resources

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Lecturer:

-1-

ABSTRACT

What is being? How is being to understood. According

to Joseph Omoregbe, a professor of philosophy, this is the fundamental question of philosophy and the central question of metaphysics. This idea of being has been there from the earliest time in philosophy to our own time.

ONTOLOGY (BEING)

Being etymologically derived from the Greek word means "to be". Ontology is the branch of philosophy that studies concepts such as existence, being, becoming, and reality. It includes the questions of how entities are grouped into basic categories and which of these entities exist on the most fundamental level. Ontology is sometimes referred to as the science of being.

It has been characterized as general metaphysics in contrast to special metaphysics, which is concerned with more particular aspects of being.

Ontologists often try to determine what the categories or highest kinds are and how they form a system of categories that provides an encompassing classification of all entities. Commonly proposed categories include substances, properties, relations, states of affairs and events. These categories are characterized by fundamental ontological concepts, like particularity and universality, abstractness and concreteness or possibility and necessity. Of special interest is the concept of ontological dependence, which determines whether the entities of a category exist on the most fundamental level. Disagreements within ontology are often about whether entities belonging to a certain category exist and, if so, how they are related to other entities.

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Philosophers often suppose a certain sense of being as primary, and from it derive other senses of being as secondary. So, even if they use the same word "is," the meaning of being is different, depending upon what it is that "is": sensible material beings, values and norms, principles, mathematical objects, quality, time, space, God, etc. For Plato the primary kind of being is the immutable world of ideas, while for Aristotle it is the mutable world of substances. In another context, however, Aristotle put one immutable

substance, God, as the principle of all being, and Thomas Aquinas, too, conceived God as the primary being, from which all other beings in the world receive their existence. Materialists conceive material or a sensible entity as the primary model of being, while idealists regard thought or spirit as primary. Most philosophers, including Aristotle, Edmund Husserl and Martin Heidegger, were aware of these diverse senses of being.

Inquiries into being often contrast it with its reciprocal concept, and the meaning of being varies accordingly. Paired sets include: being and becoming, being and non-being, being and appearance or phenomena, being and existence, being and essence, being and beings, being and thought, and being and ought.

How to approach the question of being is determined by the style of thought, philosophical approach, or methodology. For example, the phenomenological approaches of Husserl and Heidegger locate the question of being on the horizon of human consciousness and existence. Eastern philosophies emphasize the role of "non-being" for our understanding of being.

Many philosophical and religious traditions seem to agree that elucidating the nature of being discloses a fundamental distinction between an essential world and a resultant world of phenomena. They also seem to agree that each of the two worlds has diversity within itself with some kind of purposiveness. Yet they give different answers to the question of which of the two worlds is more real.

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A HISTORY OF THE NOTION OF BEING IN THE WEST

The pre-Socratic question of being

The pre-Socratic Greeks had a more direct, non-conceptual, and non-objectifying approach to the question of "being," as compared with the rather indirect approach of Plato and Aristotle that attempted to conceptualize and objectify "being" through instantiated forms or formed matter.

For the pre-Socratics, the most important question to be answered was: What is the world made of? In answering this question, they were immediately convinced that all things in the world are identical in nature with one another. Hence,

they successively attempted to reduce the world in general to water (Thales), then to air (Anaximenes), then to fire (Heraclitus), until Parmenides finally said that the whole world is made of "being" (whatever exists). Parmenides' answer was more persuasive because while it was not at once evident that water, air, and fire are completely identical, it was undeniable that they all have in common the property of being, because they all are. Being, then, was considered to be the fundamental and ultimate element of all that is.

What, then, is "being"? It turned out to be a difficult question to answer indeed. The question of what water, air, or fire is, looked much easier because the definition of any of these was quite self-evident. So, Parmenides did not discuss what being is, but instead highlighted the fact of being as the truth and characterized being as one, all-inclusive, whole, unborn, timeless, immobile, unchanging, permanent, and eternal. Thus, any individual things that look mutable and perishable in the world are our illusory perceptions, and they do not belong to the realm of being. He thus introduces the idea of appearance and reality. In this way, he holds that only in appearance are things multiple and changing. In reality, he holds that being is eternal and unchanging. For him only reason can make us comprehend this.

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Usually contrasted with Parmenides' notion of being as the ultimate principle that is unchanging and eternal, is Heraclitus' understanding of fire as the ultimate element of reality, according to which the whole of reality is mutable and transitory like fire. For Heraclitus, everything is in flux and becoming, and immutability or stability is illusory. Perhaps the only sense in which he was able to talk about true being was this unchanging principle of transitory passage and its cyclicity.

Plato and Aristotle

Plato, like Parmenides, believes that being is eternal and unchanging. Plato, however, differs in that he believes that being is multiple. He believes that the individual things that we have in this world are imperfect and changing. But they are only a reflection of the things in the world of forms or ideas where there are perfect and unchanging things.

Plato differentiated between the immutable world of ideas or forms and the transitory world, saying that the former is an eternal, incorporeal realm of ideas and values that are true beings, while the latter is a less real, ephemeral, "shadowy" world of material things that are far from true beings and subject to change and decay. This way, Plato struck a compromise between Parmenides' notion of being and Heraclitus' theory of becoming, although for Plato the world of ideas is more important than the transitory world. Both are linked through the participation of the latter in the former, and the latter's degree of reality is determined by how much material things partake and manifest ideas which are true reality. The latter world, while being thus differentiated from the former, is also differentiated from the realm of non-being that is unformed matter; it constitutes an intermediate stage of becoming between being and non-being.

For Aristotle, the science of "being" was what he called "first philosophy," as is discussed in his *Metaphysics*. but his understanding of being was quite different from Plato's. For Aristotle, only individual things, called substances, are fully

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beings, while other things such as quantity, quality, relation, place, and time, called categories, have a derivative kind of being, dependent on individual substances. Thus, all senses of being are derived from a single central notion, the notion of "substance." According to him, however, whereas each individual substance is a mutable thing composite of two correlative principles: form and matter, or, in more general terms, actuality and potentiality, there is one immutable substance, God, who is pure form devoid of matter. God as the highest genus of substance is therefore the principle of all being and dealt with also in first philosophy.

Medieval philosophers

Medieval philosophy basically followed the Aristotelian understanding of the various senses of being in reality.

One new development in Medieval philosophy was the distinctive notion of "existence," which means to "to exist," "to appear," or "to emerge". Greek ontology apparently did not have it, since its primary focus was the matter of predication based on copula sentences of the form "X is Y."

The best Aristotle came up with based on the primarily predicative verb *einai* was the distinction between that it is and what it is, which could mean "existence" and "essence," respectively. Medieval philosophy, however, developed the notion of existence distinctively under the influence of Islamic philosophy, which distinguished existence from essence in light of a biblical metaphysics of creation within Islam which differentiated the contingent existence of the created world from the necessary status of God. Thomas Aquinas holds that only God, being the foundation of all things, can be properly called being, that human beings are only called beings by extension (analogously). Thomas Aquinas adopted this, maintaining that the essence and existence of each and every contingent, finite creature are distinct, while essence and existence are identical within God, who is therefore preeminent over the world. Thus, even when rejecting Anselm's ontological proof for God's existence that had argued that to know what God is (his essence) is to know that

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God exists (his existence), Aquinas did not reject the identification of God's essence and God's existence.

Interestingly, according to Aquinas, because of his preeminent status over the world, God is now "the first being", and each and every individual creature is a "participated being" which derives its being from God as the first being. Thus, although God and creatures are not totally similar, they are at least proportionately similar, i.e., analogical in their relationship through the "analogy of being". Duns Scotus, however, denied this, suggesting the univocity of being, although he still recognized that God as necessary being (being that is not created) and creatures as contingent beings derived from another. He thinks that if we cannot use the word being in the same way for God and man, we will not be able to move from the idea of man as finite being to God as an infinite being.

Modern philosophers

Empiricists and materialists in modern philosophy such as Thomas Hobbes took a sensible material thing as the model of being and identified sensibility or physicality as the primary sense of being. This perspective of being has been dominant

throughout modern times.

At the same time, there were also rationalists and idealists who did not agree with empiricists and materialists. Baruch Spinoza, a rationalist with his pantheistic recognition of only one "substance" (God or Nature), regarded this "substance" as the primary sense of being and referred to "mode" as the derivative sense of being, ontologically and conceptually derivative from the former. For substance is "that which is in itself, and is conceived through itself," while mode is "the modifications of substance, or that which exists in, and conceived through, something other than itself." Thus, substance and mode are two main senses of being, although Spinoza suggested that being itself has, in the strict sense, no proper definition.

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For absolute idealist Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel, "being" coincides with "thought," because the subject matter of philosophy is the life of the Absolute Spirit, self-thinking Thought, as manifested panentheistically in the universe. The Absolute Spirit manifests itself in the universe by going out of itself and returning to itself. This life of the Absolute Spirit has three main phases: itself, nature, and the human spirit; and they are dealt with by logic, the philosophy of nature, and the philosophy of spirit, respectively. Thus, logic deals with how the Absolute Spirit conceives of itself before the creation of the universe. Logic begins with "being", which is the most immediate and indeterminate concept the Absolute Spirit can formulate about itself. But, being is so completely indeterminate that it passes over into "non-being" or "nothing", its negation, which is also completely indeterminate. Non-being also easily moves back to being. So, a third category, "becoming", is posited, which is the synthesis, at a higher level, of being as thesis and non-being as antithesis. While being and non-being are wholly indeterminate abstractions, becoming is "the first concrete thought," thus being able to become "determinate being", which is a definite being. Although notions such as being "in itself", being "for itself", and being "in and for itself" are also developed from determinate being, the original dialectic of being, non-being, and becoming is the starting point of the whole dialectic life of the Absolute Spirit that involves all

other senses of being through the triads of thesis, antithesis, and synthesis at various phases and sub-phases.

Husserl and Heidegger

In the late nineteenth century, Edmund Husserl recognized that various kinds of being such as normative beings, values, space, time, mathematical objects, logical objects, historical object, and others do exist in different senses. Husserl gained this insight probably from his teacher Franz Brentano who had elaborated it in his *On the Several Senses of Being in Aristotle*. Husserl, thus, developed phenomenology as a philosophical methodology which can describe multiple senses of being as the world of the "transcendental ego" or

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"pure consciousness." For example, in describing in which sense "time" exists, Husserl inquired into how time presents itself to us and developed a phenomenology of time. Similarly, for all kinds of objects, Husserl inquired into how each of them presents its sense of being to human subjects. Although Husserl did not finish this project, he at least laid the foundation of its philosophical methodology.

Martin Heidegger, a student of Husserl, took the question of being (ontology) as the primary subject of philosophy.

Heidegger raised the question: Do we in our time have an answer to the question of what we really mean by the word being? He distinguishes between being itself and individual beings. He however deliberately refused to identify being itself with God.

Heidegger complained that the question of being has failed to be answered in the long philosophical tradition in the West because since Plato and Aristotle the notion of being has always been conceptualized and objectified through instantiated forms or formed matter. He, however, appreciated pre-Socratics' approach to the direct disclosure of being, and suggested that for this kind of direct disclosure of "being", the human being should be thrown to the phenomenal world of "beings" as literally "being-there". By being confronted with "non-being" there, the human being experiences dread about death (the negation of being) and grasps the meaning of being in beings. His methodology of inquiring into the meaning of being is called hermeneutic

phenomenology, resulting from a combination of phenomenology and hermeneutics. In his inquiry into the meaning of being, Heidegger explicated the roles of death and conscience, teleological interdependence of being, and other unique elements.

Jean Paul Satre

Jean Paul Satre who is an existentialist philosopher and a self proclaimed atheist dismisses trying to explain being in terms of derivation, participation or creation. For him whatever exists is being. Being is superfluous; it is just there and no reason could be given for it's existence.

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Meister Eckhart

Meister Eckhart holds that at the outset, God is all, the creature is nothing; at the ultimate stage, "the soul is above God." The driving power of this process is detachment.

"All creatures are pure nothingness. I do not say they are small or petty: they are pure nothingness." Whereas God inherently possesses being, creatures do not possess being but receive it derivatively. Outside God, there is pure nothingness. "The being (of things) is God." The "noble man" moves among things in detachment, knowing that they are nothing in themselves and yet aware that they are full of God—their being."

THE NOTION OF BEING IN NON-WESTERN TRADITIONS

The Hebrew Bible

The Hebrew equivalent to the English word "to be" is *hayah*. But, it is hardly used as predicative or as existential. For the predicative purpose, the so-called noun clause is used without copula most likely; and for the existential purpose, the particle *yēš* ("there is"), which is no longer a verb, is used most likely. Therefore, in most cases the verb *hayah* means "to come to be" or "to come to pass." This does not mean that this verb is equivalent to the English verb "to become." So, for example, "the earth was waste" (Genesis 1:2), where *hayahis*, the past tense of *hayah*, is used, actually does not mean to equate "the earth" and "waste," but to show that "the earth came to be waste," if not that "the earth became waste." It is interesting to observe that the Hebrew verb *hayah* shows an act more dynamic than the English verb "to be."

Eastern philosophies

Eastern philosophies, while having the notion of "being" like Western thought does, have tended to recognize the notion of "non-being" more than Western thought does. Hinduism

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distinguishes between being and non-being, equating the former with the enduring reality of Brahman, the supreme cosmic power, and the latter with the illusory unreality of the manifested universe. Hinduism, however, has another, diametrically opposed use of these terms especially in its mysticism, where non-being means that boundless and eternal metaphysical expanse of void even beyond Brahman and the universe because of which even being itself is and endures.

Buddhism accepts the Buddha's teaching that everything in the world is marked by three main characteristics: 1) impermanence, which not only means that everything will eventually cease to exist, but also that everything is in flux; 2) unsatisfactoriness, which means that nothing in the world can bring lasting satisfaction; and 3) non-self, which rejects the Hindu notion of self. Mahayana Buddhism extends the third characteristic of "non-self" from sentient beings to all kinds of objects in the world. The three characteristics as a whole, therefore, mean that nothing in the world possesses permanent, essential identity, and also that all things, in that regard, are dependent on each other. For Mahayana Buddhism, this means a virtual rejection of the metaphysical notion of being itself or "own-being". A doctrine of "emptiness," therefore, has been developed to show this insight into reality, so we may be led to a realm of wisdom and inner peace where we acquire the Buddha-nature.

According to Taoism, Tao ("Way") is the primordial state of oneness which unites various things in the world that emerge from it. Lao Tzu often referred to the pair of being and non-being, saying that both are contained within Tao. Neo-Daoist Wang Bi of the third century C.E., however, identified Tao with non-being and believed it to be the background of the world of being.

Multiple Senses of Being in a Paired Set of Concepts

As has been noticed above, being can often be paired with

another concept and the sense of being differs according to what it is paired with. The pairs listed below are some of those often discussed in the history of philosophy. These

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pairs, however, often overlap and they are not mutually exclusive.

IDENTITY AND CHANGE

Identity is a fundamental metaphysical concern.

Metaphysicians investigating identity are tasked with the question of what, exactly, it means for something to be identical to itself, or – more controversially – to something else. Issues of identity arise in the context of time: what does it mean for something to be itself across two moments in time? How do we account for this? Another question of identity arises when we ask what our criteria ought to be for determining identity, and how the reality of identity interfaces with linguistic expressions.

The metaphysical positions one takes on identity have far-reaching implications on issues such as the mind–body problem, personal identity, ethics, and law.

A few ancient Greeks took extreme positions on the nature of change. Parmenides denied change altogether, while Heraclitus argued that change was ubiquitous:

"No man ever steps in the same river twice."

Identity, sometimes called numerical identity, is the relation that a thing bears to itself, and which no thing bears to anything other than itself (cf. sameness).

A modern philosopher who made a lasting impact on the philosophy of identity was Leibniz, whose law of the indiscernibility of identicals is still widely accepted today. It states that if some object *x* is identical to some object *y*, then any property that *x* has, *y* will have as well.

However, it does seem that objects can change over time. Two rival theories to account for the relationship between change and identity are perdurantism, which treats objects as a series of object-stages, and endurantism, which maintains

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that the organism—the same object—is present at every

stage in its history.

By appealing to intrinsic and extrinsic properties, endurantism finds a way to harmonize identity with change. Endurantists believe that objects persist by being strictly numerically identical over time. However, if Leibniz's law of the indiscernibility of identicals is used to define numerical identity here, it seems that objects must be completely unchanged in order to persist. Discriminating between intrinsic properties and extrinsic properties, endurantists state that numerical identity means that, if some object *x* is identical to some object *y*, then any intrinsic property that *x* has, *y* will have as well.

Thus, if an object persists, intrinsic properties of it are unchanged, but extrinsic properties can change over time. Besides the object itself, environments and other objects can change over time; properties that relate to other objects would change even if this object does not change.

Perdurantism can harmonize identity with change in another way. In four-dimensionalism, a version of perdurantism, what persists is a four-dimensional object which does not change although three-dimensional slices of the object may differ.

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